VERBAL ABILITY

Complete Revision Notes — Days 1 to 8

Placement preparation | Beginner-friendly grammar rules, formulas, examples and shortcuts

Topics included

- Parts of Speech and Sentence Structure
- Subject–Verb Agreement, Conjunctions and Modal Verbs
- Articles and Prepositions
- All 12 Tenses and their sentence structures
- Singular/Plural rules and Common Grammar Errors
- Error Spotting, Sentence Correction and Sentence Improvement
- Fill in the Blanks and Sentence Completion

How to use: Revise the rules first, read the examples aloud, then practise questions. Keywords are clues, not automatic answers; always check the complete sentence.

Prepared as a study reference for common placement-level verbal questions.

DAY 1 — Grammar Foundations

1. Parts of Speech

Part of speech	Meaning / use	Examples
Noun	Names a person, place, animal, thing or idea	Rahul, India, dog, book, honesty
Pronoun	Replaces a noun	I, we, you, he, she, it, they
Verb	Shows an action or state	run, eat, study, is, are, was
Adjective	Describes a noun or pronoun	beautiful, intelligent, red, tall
Adverb	Describes a verb, adjective or another adverb	quickly, slowly, very, carefully
Preposition	Shows relationship of place, time or direction	in, on, at, under, from
Conjunction	Joins words or clauses	and, but, or, because, although
Interjection	Expresses sudden feeling	Wow!, Alas!, Hurrah!, Oh!

Remember: Many adverbs end in -ly (slowly, carefully), but not all do. Some -ly words are adjectives too (friendly, lovely).

2. Sentence Structure

• **Sentence:** a group of words that gives complete meaning.

• **Subject (S):** who or what the sentence is about; often performs the action.

• **Verb (V):** action or state.

• **Object (O):** receives the action.

• **Complement (C):** completes the meaning by describing or identifying the subject/object.

Pattern	Example	Breakdown
SV	Birds fly.	Birds = S; fly = V
SVO	Ram eats rice.	Ram = S; eats = V; rice = O
SVC	She is intelligent.	She = S; is = V; intelligent = C

3. Basic Subject–Verb Agreement

• In the simple present, he/she/it and a singular noun generally take a verb with -s/-es: He plays. Rahul studies.

• I/we/you/they and plural nouns take the base verb: I play. They study.

• Do not add -s/-es after does: She does not play (not does not plays).

• After do/does in questions and negatives, use the base verb (V1).

Examples: He works every day. They work every day. Does she like tea? She does not like tea.

4. Conjunctions

Conjunction	Use	Example
and	Adds information	Ravi and Rani are friends.
but	Shows contrast	He is poor but honest.
or	Gives a choice	Tea or coffee?
because	Gives a reason	I stayed home because it rained.
so	Shows a result	It rained, so I stayed home.
although	Shows contrast	Although tired, she continued.
if	Introduces a condition	If you practise, you will improve.

Conjunction	Use	Example
unless	Means 'if not'	Unless you hurry, you will miss the bus.
while	Actions at the same time / contrast	While I studied, he cooked.
either...or	One of two choices	Either Ram or Ravi will come.
neither...nor	Not one and not the other	Neither tea nor coffee is available.
both...and	Includes two things	Both Ram and Ravi attended.
not only...but also	Adds emphasis	She is not only smart but also kind.

Common trap: Do not normally use 'although' and 'but' together for the same contrast: say 'Although he was tired, he worked' OR 'He was tired, but he worked.'

5. Modal Verbs

Modal / phrase	Main use	Example
can	Ability; informal permission	I can swim.
could	Past ability; polite request	Could you help me?
may	Formal permission; possibility	May I come in?
might	Possibility, often less certain	It might rain.
should	Advice / recommendation	You should practise daily.
must	Strong obligation / necessity	You must wear a helmet.
will	Future / promise	I will call you.
would	Polite request / hypothetical situation	Would you help me?
shall	Offer / suggestion	Shall we begin?
ought to	Moral duty / advice	You ought to respect others.
need to	Necessity	You need to study.
have to / has to	External obligation	I have to go. He has to go.
had to	Past obligation	I had to leave early.
must not	Prohibition	You must not park here.
need not	No necessity	You need not worry.
would rather	Preference	I would rather stay home.
used to	Past habit / past state	I used to play cricket.

Modal formula: Subject + modal + V1. Examples: She can sing; He should study; They will come. Do not add -s/-es or 'to' after ordinary modals. Exceptions include 'ought to', 'have to', 'need to' and 'used to'.

- Negative: modal + not + V1 — cannot, should not, must not, will not.
- Question: modal + subject + V1? — Can you swim? Should we start?
- Can vs could: present ability vs past ability / polite request.
- May vs might: permission or possibility vs weaker possibility.
- Should vs must: advice vs strong obligation.

DAY 2 — Articles and Prepositions

1. Articles: A, An, The

Article	Rule	Examples
A	Before a singular countable noun beginning with a consonant sound	a boy, a car, a university, a useful book, a European country
An	Before a singular countable noun beginning with a vowel sound	an apple, an egg, an honest person, an hour, an MBA
The	For a specific/known noun; unique things; superlatives; ordinals	the book on the table, the Sun, the best, the first

• Choose a/an by **sound**, not spelling: 'a university' starts with /y/ sound; 'an hour' has a silent h.

• Use 'a/an' when mentioning one non-specific singular countable noun for the first time.

• Use 'the' when the noun is specific or has already been mentioned: I bought a book. The book is interesting.

• Do not normally use an article before plural or uncountable nouns when speaking generally: Books are useful. Water is essential.

2. Prepositions: Place, Time and Direction

Preposition	Common use	Examples
in	Cities, countries, enclosed spaces, years, parts of day	in Hyderabad; in India; in a room; in 2025; in the morning
on	Surfaces, days and dates	on the table; on Monday; on 5 May
at	Exact time or specific point; at night	at 9 AM; at the bus stop; at night
by	Deadline or method	by Monday; by bus
for	Duration or purpose	for two hours; a gift for you
since	Starting point in time	since 2023; since Monday
from	Origin / starting place	from Vijayawada
to	Direction / destination	go to college
with	Together / using something	with my friend; cut with a knife
under / over	Lower / higher position	under the table; over the bridge
between / among	Between two / within a group	between Ram and Ravi; among friends
beside / behind	Next to / at the back of	beside me; behind the house

3. Fixed Preposition Combinations

Expression	Correct combination
interested	interested in cybersecurity
good / bad	good at maths; bad at spelling
afraid / proud	afraid of dogs; proud of her work
famous / responsible	famous for its food; responsible for the task
different / similar	different from mine; similar to yours
married	married to a doctor
excited / worried	excited about the trip; worried about the result
listen / depend / belong	listen to music; depend on parents; belong to me
wait / look	wait for the bus; look at the board; look for keys

Expression	Correct combination
believe / apologize	believe in yourself; apologize for the mistake
apply / suffer	apply for a job; suffer from a cold
agree / participate	agree with me; participate in the event
reason / solution / need	reason for; solution to; need for
interest / knowledge / relationship	interest in; knowledge of; relationship with

4. Common Preposition Errors

Incorrect	Correct	Rule
discuss about the issue	discuss the issue	Discuss takes a direct object.
reach to the office	reach the office	Reach normally takes no preposition.
prefer tea than coffee	prefer tea to coffee	Prefer X to Y.
explain me the rule	explain the rule to me	Explain something to someone.
return back home	return home	Return already means go back.
married with	married to	Fixed expression.
enter into the classroom	enter the classroom	Enter a place directly; 'enter into' is possible in other contexts.
comprises of five members	comprises five members	Use 'comprises' or 'is composed of'.

Difference: 'interested in' describes curiosity or liking; 'good at' describes skill or ability. Fixed combinations must usually be learned as phrases.

DAY 3 — Simple Tenses

1. Verb Forms: V1, V2 and V3

V1 (base)	V2 (past)	V3 (past participle)
go	went	gone
eat	ate	eaten
write	wrote	written
come	came	come
see	saw	seen
buy	bought	bought
take	took	taken
speak	spoke	spoken
do	did	done
give	gave	given
play	played	played
complete	completed	completed

2. Simple Present

Use: habits, routines, repeated actions, general truths and facts.

Sentence type	Formula	Example
Positive	I/we/you/they + V1; he/she/it + V1+s/es	She works. They work.
Negative	Subject + do/does not + V1	He does not play.
Question	Do/Does + subject + V1?	Does she study?

• He/she/it/singular noun: add -s/-es — plays, goes, watches, studies, teaches, fixes, does, has.

• I/we/you/they/plural noun: use V1 — I play; they study.

• After does/does not, use V1: Does he go? He does not go.

Common clues: every day, daily, always, usually, often, sometimes, generally, regularly, never, on Sundays.

3. Simple Past

Use: an action completed at a definite time in the past.

Sentence type	Formula	Example
Positive	Subject + V2	She went home.
Negative	Subject + did not + V1	She did not go home.
Question	Did + subject + V1?	Did she go home?

Common clues: yesterday, last night/week/month/year, two days ago, a few minutes ago, previously, earlier, in 2024 (when the time is finished).

Important: After did/did not, always use V1: 'Did he eat?' not 'Did he ate?'; 'They did not come' not 'They did not came.'

4. Simple Future

Sentence type	Formula	Example
Positive	Subject + will + V1	I will attend the exam.

Sentence type	Formula	Example
Negative	Subject + will not + V1	I will not attend.
Question	Will + subject + V1?	Will you attend?

Common clues: tomorrow, day after tomorrow, next week/month/year, soon, later, in two days, one day, in the future.

Core shortcut: will + V1. Do not write 'will goes' or 'will went'; write 'will go.'

DAY 4 — Continuous Tenses

1. Present Continuous

Use: an action happening now or around the present time.

Type	Formula	Example
Positive	Subject + am/is/are + V-ing	I am studying. He is reading. They are playing.
Negative	Subject + am/is/are + not + V-ing	She is not sleeping.
Question	Am/Is/Are + subject + V-ing?	Are they working?

• I → am; he/she/it or singular noun → is; we/you/they or plural noun → are.

• Clues: now, right now, at present, currently, at the moment, Look!, Listen!, these days (depending on context).

• Spelling: make→making; write→writing; run→running; sit→sitting; swim→swimming; lie→lying.

2. Past Continuous

Use: an action that was in progress at a particular time in the past.

Type	Formula	Example
Positive	Subject + was/were + V-ing	I was studying. They were playing.
Negative	Subject + was/were not + V-ing	He was not sleeping.
Question	Was/Were + subject + V-ing?	Were you reading?

• I/he/she/it → was; we/you/they → were.

• Clues: while, when, at that time, at that moment, yesterday at 5 PM.

• 'When' often introduces a shorter action that interrupts: I was sleeping when he called.

• 'While' often introduces an action in progress: While I was studying, my brother was watching TV.

3. Future Continuous

Use: an action that will be in progress at a particular future time.

Type	Formula	Example
Positive	Subject + will be + V-ing	I will be studying tomorrow evening.
Negative	Subject + will not be + V-ing	I will not be working.
Question	Will + subject + be + V-ing?	Will you be travelling?

Clues: this time tomorrow, at this time next week, tomorrow evening, at 5 PM tomorrow, next Monday at 10 AM.

Tense	Formula	Example
Present continuous	am/is/are + V-ing	I am studying now.
Past continuous	was/were + V-ing	I was studying yesterday.
Future continuous	will be + V-ing	I will be studying tomorrow.

DAY 5 — Perfect and Perfect Continuous Tenses

1. Present Perfect

Use: an action completed in the past with a connection to the present; the exact finished past time is usually not stated.

Type	Formula	Example
Positive	Subject + has/have + V3	She has completed the task. They have eaten.
Negative	Subject + has/have not + V3	He has not arrived.
Question	Has/Have + subject + V3?	Have you finished?

• He/she/it/singular noun → has; I/we/you/they/plural noun → have.

• Clues: just, already, yet, ever, never, recently, lately, so far, until now, up to now.

• Use simple past with a definite finished time: 'I visited yesterday.' Present perfect: 'I have visited that place.'

2. Past Perfect

Use: an action completed before another action or time in the past.

Type	Formula	Example
Positive	Subject + had + V3	The train had left before I arrived.
Negative	Subject + had not + V3	She had not eaten.
Question	Had + subject + V3?	Had they finished?

Clues: before, after, by the time, already, until then, earlier, previously. 'Had' is used with every subject.

3. Future Perfect

Use: an action that will be completed before a specified future time.

Type	Formula	Example
Positive	Subject + will have + V3	I will have completed it by tomorrow.
Negative	Subject + will not have + V3	She will not have arrived by then.
Question	Will + subject + have + V3?	Will you have finished by Monday?

Clues: by tomorrow, by next week/month, by then, by 2030, before a future deadline, by the time.

4. Present Perfect Continuous

Use: an action that started in the past and has continued up to now; focus is on duration.

Type	Formula	Example
Positive	Subject + has/have been + V-ing	I have been studying for two hours.
Negative	Subject + has/have not been + V-ing	He has not been working.
Question	Has/Have + subject + been + V-ing?	Have you been waiting?

Since = starting point (since 2023, since Monday). **For** = duration (for two hours, for three years).

5. Past Perfect Continuous

Use: an action that continued for a period before another past action/time.

Type	Formula	Example
Positive	Subject + had been + V-ing	I had been studying for two hours before he arrived.
Negative	Subject + had not been + V-ing	They had not been waiting long.

Type	Formula	Example
Question	Had + subject + been + V-ing?	Had she been working?

6. Future Perfect Continuous

Use: an action that will have continued for a period up to a particular future point.

Type	Formula	Example
Positive	Subject + will have been + V-ing	By June, I will have been working here for a year.
Negative	Subject + will not have been + V-ing	He will not have been living here long.
Question	Will + subject + have been + V-ing?	Will they have been studying for two hours?

7. All 12 Tenses — Quick Formula Chart

Tense	Positive structure	Example
Simple Present	V1 / V1+s/es	She works.
Simple Past	V2	She worked.
Simple Future	will + V1	She will work.
Present Continuous	am/is/are + V-ing	She is working.
Past Continuous	was/were + V-ing	She was working.
Future Continuous	will be + V-ing	She will be working.
Present Perfect	has/have + V3	She has worked.
Past Perfect	had + V3	She had worked.
Future Perfect	will have + V3	She will have worked.
Present Perfect Continuous	has/have been + V-ing	She has been working.
Past Perfect Continuous	had been + V-ing	She had been working.
Future Perfect Continuous	will have been + V-ing	She will have been working.

DAY 6 — Advanced Grammar Rules

1. Advanced Subject–Verb Agreement

Rule	Correct example	Remember
Each / Every + singular noun	Each student has a laptop.	Use singular verb.
Everyone / someone / nobody / anybody	Everyone is ready.	These are grammatically singular.
Either...or / Neither...nor	Neither the students nor the teacher is ready.	Verb usually agrees with the nearer subject.
A number of + plural noun	A number of students are absent.	Use plural verb.
The number of + plural noun	The number of students is increasing.	Use singular verb.
Along with / as well as / together with	Ram, along with his friends, is coming.	Verb agrees with the main subject.
Uncountable nouns	The information is useful.	Usually singular: information, furniture, advice, news.
Mathematics / physics / economics	Mathematics is difficult.	Subject name is usually singular.

Nearer-subject examples: Either the manager or the employees are attending. Either the employees or the manager is attending.

2. Singular and Plural

Rule	Singular	Plural
Add -s	book	books
Add -es after s, sh, ch, x, z	class	classes
Consonant + y → ies	city; baby	cities; babies
Vowel + y → add s	boy; key	boys; keys
Irregular	child; man; woman	children; men; women
Irregular	foot; tooth; mouse	feet; teeth; mice

3. Same Form in Singular and Plural

Some count nouns have the same form in singular and plural. The verb changes according to meaning.

Word	Singular example	Plural example
sheep	One sheep is grazing.	Five sheep are grazing.
deer	This deer is young.	Those deer are young.
fish	One fish is in the bowl.	Many fish are in the pond.
aircraft	An aircraft is landing.	Two aircraft are landing.
species	This species is rare.	Many species are protected.
series	This series is popular.	These series are popular.
means	This is a useful means.	These are useful means.

Other same-form examples include salmon, trout, bison, swine, spacecraft, hovercraft and offspring. 'Fish' is commonly unchanged for plural, though 'fishes' can refer to different species.

Do not confuse: 'news' is an uncountable singular noun (The news is good); it is not a zero-plural count noun.

4. Always-Plural Nouns and Pair Expressions

• Scissors, trousers, spectacles, shorts and jeans normally take plural verbs: These scissors are sharp.

• When using 'a pair of', the subject is singular: A pair of scissors is on the table.

• A pair of trousers is expensive. Two pairs of trousers are expensive.

5. Common Grammar Errors

Incorrect	Correct	Rule
He go to college.	He goes to college.	He/she/it + V1+s/es in simple present.
She did not went.	She did not go.	Did + V1.
He does not plays.	He does not play.	Does + V1.
She have a laptop.	She has a laptop.	Singular subject takes has.
discuss about the topic	discuss the topic	No 'about' after discuss.
interested on cybersecurity	interested in cybersecurity	Fixed preposition.
good in mathematics	good at mathematics	Fixed preposition.
married with him	married to him	Fixed preposition.
prefer tea than coffee	prefer tea to coffee	Prefer X to Y.
more taller	taller	Do not double the comparative.
most smartest	smartest	Do not double the superlative.
enjoy to play	enjoy playing	Enjoy + V-ing.
want going	want to go	Want + to + V1.

DAY 7 — Error Spotting and Sentence Correction

1. Error Spotting

In error spotting, a sentence is divided into parts. Identify the part that contains a grammar error. If every part is correct, choose 'No error'.

Check in this order:

• Subject–verb agreement: He go → He goes.

• Tense and helping verb: did not went → did not go.

• Articles: an university → a university.

• Prepositions: interested on → interested in.

• Singular/plural: one of the student → one of the students.

• Verb form: enjoy to dance → enjoy dancing.

• Comparison: more better → better.

• If all parts are grammatically correct, choose 'No error'.

Example: 'She / do not / like coffee.' Error = 'do not'; correct sentence: 'She does not like coffee.'

2. Sentence Correction

Choose the grammatically correct replacement or sentence.

Incorrect sentence	Correct sentence
He go to school.	He goes to school.
I am living here since 2020.	I have been living here since 2020.
She did not went.	She did not go.
An university is nearby.	A university is nearby.
He is good in mathematics.	He is good at mathematics.
This is more better.	This is better.

3. Comparative and Superlative Rules

Type	Rule	Example
Short adjective — comparative	Usually add -er + than	tall → taller than; fast → faster than
Long adjective — comparative	Use more + adjective + than	more intelligent than; more beautiful than
Superlative	Usually -est or most; use 'the'	the tallest; the most intelligent
Irregular	Learn the special form	good → better → best; bad → worse → worst

Important: 'Rahul is more intelligent than Ram' is correct. Do not mark it as an error.

DAY 8 — Sentence Improvement, Blanks and Completion

1. Sentence Improvement

Replace an incorrect or awkward expression with a grammatically correct one.

Incorrect expression	Correct expression
more better	better
discuss about the issue	discuss the issue
return back	return
prefer tea than coffee	prefer tea to coffee
senior than me	senior to me
despite of the rain	despite the rain
one of the best student	one of the best students
cope up with the problem	cope with the problem
No sooner...when	No sooner...than
Hardly...than	Hardly...when

Paired structures: No sooner had the train arrived than it started raining. Hardly had I reached home when it began to rain.

2. Fill in the Blanks

A blank may test tense, subject–verb agreement, articles, prepositions, modals, conjunctions or vocabulary.

• Read the full sentence before selecting an option.

• Find the time clue: yesterday usually points to simple past; tomorrow may point to simple future.

• Check the subject: 'He ___' may require 'has/is/works'; 'They ___' may require 'have/are/work'.

• Check the word before the blank: 'interested ___' → in; 'good ___' → at.

• Check the meaning: 'You should wear a helmet' gives advice; 'might wear' expresses possibility.

• Check the structure: after did/does/will/can/should, use V1.

3. Sentence Completion

Choose the ending that completes the sentence grammatically and logically.

Starter / connector	Meaning / expected relationship	Example
If	Condition	If you work hard, you will succeed.
Unless	If not	Unless you practise, you will not improve.
Although	Contrast	Although she was tired, she continued working.
Because	Reason	He missed the bus because he woke up late.
So / therefore	Result	It rained, so we stayed inside.
Despite	Contrast; followed by noun / V-ing phrase	Despite being tired, he continued.
Even though	Strong contrast	Even though it was late, they continued.

• Check grammar: 'If I were a manager, I would lead the team.'

• Check logic: 'He was hungry, so he ate some food.'

• Check contrast: 'Although she was tired, she continued working.'

• Check result: 'She saved money; therefore, she accumulated savings.'

• Avoid options that are grammatically possible but do not make sense in context.

FINAL REVISION — QUICK PLACEMENT SHORTCUTS

1. Ten High-Value Grammar Shortcuts

Clue / structure	Rule	Example
Yesterday / ago / last week	Usually simple past; use V2	She went yesterday.
Did / did not	Use V1 after did	Did he come?
He / she / it in simple present	Use V1+s/es	He works.
Does / does not	Use V1 after does	Does she play?
Will	Use V1 after will	They will come.
Has / have + V3	Present perfect	She has eaten.
Had + V3	Past perfect	They had left.
Am / is / are + V-ing	Present continuous	He is reading.
Was / were + V-ing	Past continuous	They were playing.
Will have + V3	Future perfect	I will have finished.

2. Common Tense Keywords — Placement Focus

Tense	Common clues (context matters)
Simple Present	every day, daily, always, usually, often, sometimes, regularly, never
Simple Past	yesterday, last night/week, ago, previously, earlier, in 2024 (finished time)
Simple Future	tomorrow, next week/month, soon, later, in two days, in the future
Present Continuous	now, right now, currently, at present, at the moment, Look!, Listen!
Past Continuous	while, when, at that time, at that moment, yesterday at 5 PM
Future Continuous	this time tomorrow, tomorrow evening, at 5 PM tomorrow
Present Perfect	just, already, yet, ever, never, recently, so far, until now
Past Perfect	before, after, by the time, already, until then, earlier
Future Perfect	by tomorrow, by next week, by then, by 2030
Perfect Continuous	since, for, all day, all morning; use sentence context to identify the time.

Warning: Keywords are clues, not fixed rules. 'Since' and 'for' can appear in more than one tense. Identify whether the action continues to now, continued before a past event, or will continue up to a future point.

3. Common Verb Patterns

Pattern	Example
Modal + V1	She can speak.
Do / does / did + V1	Did you go?
Will + V1	I will call.
Has / have / had + V3	They have finished.
Be verb + V-ing	She is studying.
Enjoy + V-ing	I enjoy reading.
Want + to + V1	I want to learn.
Prefer X to Y	I prefer tea to coffee.
One of the + plural noun	One of the students is absent.

Pattern	Example
A pair of + plural-form item + singular verb	A pair of scissors is here.

4. Common Exam Approach

• Read the entire sentence; do not decide from one word alone.

• Find the subject and verb first.

• Identify the time reference and helping verb.

• Check whether the verb form is V1, V2, V3 or V-ing.

• Check articles, prepositions and singular/plural agreement.

• For sentence completion, check both grammar and meaning.

• For error spotting, if no part is wrong, select 'No error'.

Revision status: This PDF covers the concepts and rules taught from Day 1 through Day 8. It is a revision guide, not a substitute for timed practice.